

Portfolio Checklist

A checklist to make sure your portfolio actually gets you hired, not just admired.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Designers preparing a portfolio for job applications, freelance clients, or a school application — who want it to convert interest into opportunities, not just collect compliments.

HOW TO USE IT

Audit your current portfolio against every item below. A portfolio that scores well here will do more work for your career than ten extra projects added without this filter.

1. CURATION

[] Portfolio shows 4–8 strong projects, not everything you've ever made.

A weak project pulls down every strong one next to it.

[] Every project included is your best current level of work — nothing left in "just to have more."

[] Projects show range across the kind of work you actually want to be hired for.

[] If you do both strong and weak types of work, the weak ones are left out entirely.

2. CASE STUDY DEPTH

[] Each project shows more than final visuals — process, sketches, or decisions are visible somewhere.

[] Each project states the problem it solved, not just "a logo for a coffee shop."

[] Each project explains your specific role, especially for team or agency work.

[] At least one project includes a result or outcome, even an informal one (client quote, before/after, launch note).

3. PRESENTATION

[] Portfolio loads fast and works on mobile — most first views happen on a phone.

[] Consistent visual system across the portfolio site itself, not just within each project.

[] No typos, broken links, or placeholder text left over from a template.

[] Contact information is easy to find within one click from any page.

4. POSITIONING

[] Homepage or about section states clearly what kind of work you do and for whom.

[] Portfolio doesn't try to appeal to everyone.

"I do branding, UI, motion, print, and illustration" reads as unfocused to a hiring manager — pick a lane, even if you can do more.

[] There's a clear next step for a visitor who likes what they see — contact form, email, booking link.

THE TEN-SECOND TEST

Show your portfolio homepage to someone unfamiliar with your work for ten seconds, then hide it. Ask what they remember. If it's not "what you do" and "that it looked professional," the homepage needs work before anything else does.

NEXT STEPS

A portfolio is a living document — revisit this checklist every time you finish a project strong enough to replace something weaker already in there. Fewer, stronger projects will outperform a long list every time.